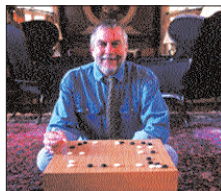




194 Lara's in Good Hands now



198 The God Of Gaming



222 Booth Babes

Digital Leisure

Technology Beyond Work

The Elder Scrolls IV OBLIVION

From Morrowind to Oblivion A long journey

The Elder Scrolls 3 a.k.a. Morrowind will always be remembered for its stunning visuals, excellent first person perspective (somewhat rare for the RPG genre), and it's hours of completely open-ended gameplay. That game was released in 2002.

It's been four long years, and Bethesda Software had a tough task ahead of them: making a game as visually splendid for today's computers as *Morrowind* was for PCs back then, at the same time re-attaining the award-winning gameplay. After all, gamers everywhere were waiting anxiously for the next game in the series. Would the sequel deliver?

Enter *The Elder Scrolls 4: Oblivion*, which was finally released in March of this year.

The Graphics

Put simply, *Oblivion* is the best-looking RPG to date, and cannot be compared to anything in the genre, eye-candy wise. We'd go as far as to say that visually, *Oblivion* is to RPG what *F.E.A.R.* was to FPS. This game has the ability to bring even X1900XT and 7900GTX cards down to the vicinity of their knees. Parallax Mapping, Shader Model 3.0, complex and soft shadows, Bloom and HDR effects, *Oblivion* has it all!

One look at the amount of detail in a single scene will be enough to convince you; the complex movements of grass and foliage, water effects, volumetric and particle effects like smoke, fire effects—all very appealing. The unfortunate thing is that the game is very resource hungry, and

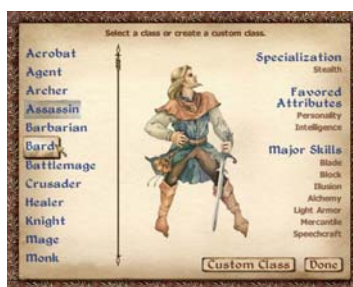
needs a real powerhouse rig to play it at 1024 x 768 with all the eye-candy turned on. And believe me when I say this: you won't want to play *Oblivion* without all the effects cranked up and with AF and AA disabled, because this game is *meant* to be played with all its bells and whistles.

Another problem with *Oblivion* (although there are third-party patches to fix it) is the LOD draw detail—it's simply horrible. You'll frequently see people suddenly appearing in front of you as you move close to their location. Similarly, a tree will appear, then its leaves will appear as you get closer, and finally, visual effects will be apparent upon getting closer. This

is because the game tries to compensate for slower cards by rendering such textures on demand. The problem is that it does this even on the most powerful systems with the latest graphics cards—very irritating.

Gameplay—Awesome As Always!

Oblivion delivers big on this front. You start off in prison, and are freed to partake on a quest for the emperor, who also gets killed early in the game. Now armed with a relic and the knowledge that the gates of *Oblivion* have been opened, pouring forth a wave of nasty creatures into the world of Tamriel, you set forth on what should be



Choose to play as one of many characters



The game looks *gorgeous*!



A treat for the eyes



My journey ends here, yours begins...